SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit and talk to the camera, deadpan. No interviewer, so prop up your own phone, or let whoever sent you this hold it, and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to whoever sent you the script. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

Making the script yours

Words in [brackets] are adjustable. The box at the top of your script sorts them: a few **must match the case file** (your clothing color, the time, a shoe size), because the kids cross-check what you say against printed evidence; if one of those is wrong for you, tell whoever sent you this before recording and it gets changed everywhere. Your clothing color only has to be true for "yesterday": wear it on camera if you can, but the lines work if you can't. The rest is flavor. Swap in your real life, your real subject, your real habits. True details get the biggest laughs.

The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Mrs. Driscoll's class Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached is your script. It's a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video by [Oct 23].

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name] · [room parent for Mrs. Driscoll's class] · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

VIDEO 1 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 1

VIDEO 1 — THE PRINCIPAL

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · The only interview with real information, and it arrives by accident. Deadpan. Hold the beats.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 1 · THE PRINCIPAL · 9:12 AM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Must match the case file: "at a meeting" at [2:15] (your alibi), and that you own exactly one squishy, [a cat]. If you'd rather own a different one, tell the room parent so the suspect table says the same thing.
- Must match the real jar: "the big one, on the high shelf [by the window], with [three] strips of tape." Describe the actual jar in the actual spot.
- Free to change: [four minutes], the kind of meeting, [tie or collar], what the squishy is for. Add one true detail about yourself; it lands harder.
- Keep exactly: saying "squishies" by accident, then "candy," then trying to un-say it. That slip is the whole party.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Look just beside the camera. Check your watch.)

I have a meeting in [four minutes], so let's make this quick.

You want to know where I was yesterday at [2:15]. I was in a meeting. I'm always in a meeting. Yesterday it was a meeting about the next meeting.

And you want to know what I know about the missing candy. Let me be very clear about this. I have not heard ANYTHING, and I know NOTHING, about anyone stealing the squishies.

(beat)

I mean candy.

(beat)

...Did I say squishies? What was I thinking! Candy. The candy. I know nothing about the candy.

(pause. Straighten your [tie or collar].)

I did not say squishies. I may have said squishies. It's a very common word. People say it all the time. In meetings. I am the principal of this school. I say a lot of words every day. Statistically, some of them are going to be "squishies."

(too fast)

And for the record, I have never even seen that jar. The big one. On the high shelf [by the window]. With the [three] strips of tape on the lid and the label that says "do not open."

(realize what you just said)

...Which I can only describe because people have described it to me. In meetings.

(pause)

Do I own any squishies myself? I'm the principal.

(beat)

...One. It's [a cat]. It's on my desk. It's for stress. This is stressful. (look at watch) I'm late.

(Stand up and walk out of frame. Leave the phone recording for 3 more seconds, then say, from off camera, slightly muffled:)

Is it off? Did it get the squishy thing? ...Can we cut the squishy thing?

(Then stop recording.)

Two takes max. Send the slightly flubbed one.

VIDEO 2 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 2

VIDEO 2 — THE GYM TEACHER

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec · Zero information. Genuinely does not understand squishies and is a little offended to be asked.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 2 · THE GYM TEACHER · 11:05 AM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Must match the case file: you were "in the building" at [2:15], you own something [orange] (the thief's color), and you genuinely don't get squishies. Wear the color on camera if you can; if you can't, the line still works, because you only claim you wore it yesterday. Don't swap the color on your own; it's the same color on the ransom note, the posters, and the case file. If it should change, the room parent changes it everywhere.
- Linked to another clue: the [foam avocado] squishy. The mummy's witness statement and the Chief's confession both mention the avocado one. Change it only if the room parent changes those too.
- Free to change: [dodgeball] (whatever unit you're actually teaching), [inflating/deflating things], [jump rope], [school color]. Swap in your real gym life.
- Keep exactly: "I just don't understand the obsession these days." The kids will quote it.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Whistle around your neck if you have one. Look just beside the camera. You are missing a [dodgeball] unit for this.)

I'm missing a [dodgeball] unit for this, so.

Where was I at [2:15] yesterday? Gym. Where I always am. [Inflating things. Deflating things.] The cycle of life.

Did I go near Mrs. Driscoll's room? I go near every room. The hallway is my warm-up lap.

(long sigh)

Okay. Can I say something about these squishies? I don't see what these kids see in squishies anyway. You squeeze it. It goes back. You squeeze it again. It goes back again. That's it. That's the whole thing. I just don't understand the obsession these days.

(beat)

So no, I didn't take that jar. Why would I take a whole jar of something I don't understand? You want to steal something, steal a good [jump rope]. Those are valuable.

(pause. If you're wearing it, look down at your shirt. If not, shrug.)

And yes, I was wearing [orange] yesterday. It's a [school color]. Half this building wears [orange]. (look back up) Are you writing that down?

(beat)

Last thing. Whoever has those squishies: there's a whole class of kids out there who can run a mile but can't go a day without squeezing a [foam avocado]. Think about that.

(stand up)

I'm going back to the gym.

(Walk out of frame. Stop recording.)

VIDEO 3 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 3

VIDEO 3 — THE LIBRARIAN

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec, WHISPERED throughout · Zero information, whispered throughout. Accidentally sounds guilty three times.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 3 · THE LIBRARIAN · 12:30 PM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Must match the case file: you were "in the building" at [2:15] (your [2:00 to 2:30] shelving window has to include it), you were wearing [orange] yesterday (same color as the ransom note and the posters; the room parent owns that color), and you love squishies. Wear the color on camera if you can; the lines work either way. Your shoe size is the one thing that clears you, so don't mention a number on camera.
- Free to change: [shelving] (any solo task you really do), [on every cart], why it's stressful, [alphabetized] (any librarian joke you like better).
- Keep exactly: "Whoever took them... check their feet." It points the kids at the footprint clue.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Whisper the entire thing, as if you're still in the library. Look just beside the camera.)

(whispering) I know I don't have to whisper. It's a habit.

Where was I at [2:15] yesterday? [Shelving]. I [shelve] from [2:00 to 2:30] every day. Alone. In the back. With no witnesses.

(pause)

That sounded worse than I meant it to.

Did I see anyone near Mrs. Driscoll's room? I saw someone in the hallway. Moving quickly. Carrying something. Wearing [orange].

(beat. If you're wearing it, look down at your clothes. If not, close your eyes.)

...I was wearing [orange].

(pause)

Do I like squishies? I love squishies. I have a squishy [on every cart]. They're very good for stress. [Shelving] is stressful. People put books back in the wrong place on purpose.

(beat. Realize how all of that sounded.)

So, to summarize: I had motive, I had access, and I was wearing [orange].

(long pause)

I'd like to amend my earlier statements.

(beat)

No. I did not take the squishies. But if I had, they would be [alphabetized] by now.

(lean in toward the camera, whisper even quieter)

One more thing for the detectives. Whoever took them... check their feet.

(sit back)

I don't know why I said that. I just felt like a detective would say that.

(Stand, push the chair in silently, walk out of frame. Stop recording.)

VIDEO 4 · PLAYS AFTER THE ARREST WARRANTS ARE READ

VIDEO 4 — THE CONFESSION — THE CHIEF

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · Starts defensive, cracks fast, ends with the location of the loot.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 4 · THE CHIEF · 1:15 PM · (recorded under protest)

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Must match the case file, because you are the one person who matches every clue: shoe size [10] (the footprint), in the building at [2:15] (the ghost words), wearing [orange] (the ransom P.S.; wear it at the party for sure, and on camera if you can), and loving squishies (the witness). If any of these should be different for you, tell the room parent before anything is printed; the footprint, the ransom note, the posters, and the case file all change together.
- Linked to other clues: "squeezed one and whispered 'so satisfying'" is Squad Nightshade's witness statement; [the avocado one] is in Squad Specter's statement and the Gym Teacher's video. Keep both.
- Must match the Principal: "[He] walked in on me" and "[he] said squishies in a MEETING once." Use the Principal's real pronoun; the slip in Video 1 only works if the Principal is the one who knew.
- Free to change: [twenty] (the real class size), [a math lesson] and [fractions] (whatever you were actually teaching), "I live here, basically."
- Keep exactly: "It IS satisfying, though," "a swamp that's learning fractions" (or your subject), and the last four lines. "A very special light" is the cue for the blacklight finale.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Arms crossed. Look just beside the camera. You are offended to be here.)

I want it on the record that I am not a suspect. I'm the Chief. The Chief is never a suspect. That's how it works.

(beat)

Yes, my shoes are a size [10]. Lots of people are a size [10].

Yes, I was in the building at [2:15]. I'm a teacher. I'm always in the building. I live here, basically.

(if you're wearing it, look down at your clothes)

Yes, I was wearing [orange]. ...I wear a lot of [orange]. It's festive.

(pause)

And yes, I heard what the witness said. That the thief squeezed one and whispered "so satisfying."

(very long pause. Quietly:)

It IS satisfying, though.

(beat. Uncross your arms. Exhale.)

Fine. FINE. It was me. I took the jar. And yes, it was squishies. It was always squishies. Do you know why I labeled it "candy"? Because if I had labeled it "squishies," that jar would have lasted eleven minutes. Do you know what it's like to teach [a math lesson] while [twenty] squishies get squeezed in rhythm? It sounds like a swamp. A swamp that's learning [fractions].

So I didn't steal it. I RELOCATED it. For safekeeping. From myself, mostly.

(wince)

And yes, the Principal knew. [He] walked in on me. Mid-relocation. Arms full. I gave [him] [the avocado one] to keep quiet. Clearly that didn't work. [He's] terrible at secrets. [He] said "squishies" in a MEETING once.

(lean in, almost proud)

Where are they now? Somewhere in that room. In plain sight. Hidden the only way a teacher knows how.

(beat)

You'd need a very special light to see them.

(look right into the lens for the first time)

Nice work, detectives. Now go find them.

(beat)

And if anyone squeezes one during math on Monday, I will do it again.

(Reach toward the camera and stop recording.)

Two takes max. Send the slightly flubbed one.